PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Ford Bronco II

1984–1990 · 1984–88 · 1989–90

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Look for a cracked 2.9 head before anything else**
  The Ranger Station says early North American 2.9 heads lost material around the valve guides and rocker pedestals, and some cracked after a single overheat. Symptoms are white exhaust smoke when warm, clean spark plugs, low compression on a cylinder, and milky residue on the oil cap or dipstick (check it warm, since condensation looks similar). Rectangular rocker pedestals and an 89TM casting mean the improved heads have been fitted.

- [ ] **Listen to the valve train**
  On the 2.9, oil reaches the lifters, rocker shaft and rockers through the two center cam bearings, so slight bearing wear can starve the top end. Loud clatter, especially after a long highway run, warrants an oil-pressure check. The Ranger Station's figures are about 20 psi at warm idle and 55 psi at 2,000 rpm. Coolant in the oil from a cracked head quickly wipes out those bearings.

- [ ] **Hunt for water leaks and cowl rust**
  The cowl drains on 1984–88 trucks clog with leaves and rust through, putting water on the front carpet and in the glove box. The 1989–90 trucks got a mesh cowl. Every year leaks at the A-pillar and roof seam, the rear drip rail, the side-glass seals and behind the top of the hatch. A passenger floor that is always wet, rain or not, is usually the heater core.

- [ ] **Judge the A4LD, especially on 1985–87 trucks**
  The Ranger Station rates 1985–87 A4LDs as the weakest, with reliability improving after the dual-solenoid change in mid-1988. Heat is the main killer. Look for dark or burnt fluid, slow or missing overdrive, and hard or erratic shifts, which can mean a ruptured vacuum modulator. Fluid in the modulator's vacuum line confirms it, and so does white exhaust smoke from ATF being drawn into the engine.

- [ ] **Read the door sticker and the front axle**
  The certification label on the driver's door post carries axle and transmission codes, so you can confirm the ratio, a limited-slip rear and the original gearbox. Dana 28 axles have 12 cover bolts and date codes starting with E; the Dana 35 has a 10-bolt cover and F codes. Only 1990 trucks built after November 1989 left the factory with a Dana 35.

- [ ] **Check the TTB and the hubs**
  Uneven tire wear points to tired beam pivot bushings, ball joints or radius-arm bushings, or a lift without camber correction. The Ranger Station advises checking the beam pivot bushings whenever the front end is apart. The factory automatic locking hubs become unreliable with age, and owners usually replace them with manual hubs.

- [ ] **Is it really a 4×4?**
  A 2WD Bronco II often has what looks like a transfer case, the BW1359 pass-through, so look for a front driveshaft, a front differential and a shifter or Touch-Drive buttons. Also look for 2WD-to-4WD conversions, which are common. Check the quality of the swapped axle, the driveshafts and the transfer-case linkage.

- [ ] **Run the recalls and question the modifications**
  NHTSA lists campaigns for locking-hub cams (1984), seat-belt anchors (1984), fuel lines and an EEC harness short (1986), handling-warning stickers on the sun visor (1987) and missing front wheel-bearing keys (1989). Ford blamed many rollovers on unsafe modifications. Treat a tall lift on a narrow 94-inch truck with suspicion and ask how it was engineered.

YEARS TO KNOW

1986	BEWARE	Fuel-injected 2.9 Cologne V6 (140 hp); Mitsubishi 2.3 turbodiesel offered; Touch-Drive electric-shift transfer case late in the year. The Ranger Station says 1986–88 2.9 heads are known to crack, and rates 1985–87 A4LD automatics the least reliable.
1987	BEWARE	Rear-wheel ABS standard; 2WD sales begin in earnest (22,286 sold per NHTSA). Still crack-prone 2.9 heads and the early A4LD, which The Ranger Station's builder's guide says to stay away from.
1989	SWEET SPOT	Facelift to match the Ranger: new hood, fenders, bumper and dashboard, 161.9 in long. Redesigned 89TM 2.9 heads largely eliminate the cracking, and The Ranger Station rates 1989-on A4LDs noticeably better than 1985–87. Ball joints move from the TTB beam to the knuckle. XLT Plus package.
1990	SWEET SPOT	Final year, with the 89TM heads. BW1354 on electric-shift trucks; Dana 35 TTB on 4×4s built from November 1989; some 2WD trucks get a true 2WD transmission. Production ends in early 1990 and the Explorer replaces it for 1991.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Shoulder-belt D-ring anchorage too weak**
  1984 · NHTSA 83V-134
- [ ] **Automatic locking-hub cams may crack**
  1984 · NHTSA 84V-023
- [ ] **EEC wiring harness short can open fuel injectors**
  1986 · NHTSA 85V-116
- [ ] **Nylon fuel-return lines may crack**
  1986 · NHTSA 85V-130
- [ ] **Spring-lock fuel couplings may not be engaged**
  1986–1987 · NHTSA 87V-139
- [ ] **Wrong lug nuts on aluminum wheels**
  1987 · NHTSA 87V-039
- [ ] **Handling-warning sticker on the sun visor won't stay on**
  1987 · NHTSA 87V-070
- [ ] **Power lumbar seat wiring can chafe**
  1986 · NHTSA 88V-145

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Door-post label codes**
  The Federal Safety Compliance Certification label on the driver's door post lists the axle code (ratio and limited slip) and the TRANS code. Ranger Station manual-transmission codes include X (TK4), 5 (TK5), D (FM145/FM146) and M (M5OD); automatics are W (C5) and T (A4LD).
- [ ] **Front axle**
  A Dana 28 TTB has a 12-bolt cover, 23-spline shafts and a date code beginning with E. A Dana 35 has a 10-bolt cover, 27-spline shafts and an F code. Only 1990 trucks built from November 1989 came with a Dana 35, so on anything earlier it's a swap.
- [ ] **2WD or 4WD**
  A 2WD truck usually still has a transfer-case-shaped BW1359 behind a 4WD-style transmission, but no front driveshaft or front differential. Late 1990 2WD trucks may have a true 2WD transmission with a bolt-on flange adapter instead.

- [ ] **Front wheel-bearing nut retaining keys missing**
  1989 · NHTSA 89V-109
- [ ] **Automatic transmission park pawl may not engage**
  1990 · NHTSA 91V-189

- [ ] **Engine and heads**
  The 2.8 (1984–85) is carbureted with a gear-driven cam. The 2.9 (1986–90) has an upper intake reading "2.9L Electronic Fuel Injection". Improved heads have rectangular rocker pedestals and 89TM castings; early heads have oval pedestals.
- [ ] **Eddie Bauer**
  1984–88 trucks are two-tone over Light Desert Tan with Eddie Bauer fender badges, a logo on the passenger side of the dash and a tan interior with pine-tree stitching. 1989–90 trucks are two-tone over Light Sandalwood and have a signature decal instead of a badge, plus striped seats with Eddie Bauer and duck headrest graphics.
- [ ] **Early-build clues**
  Removable flip-out quarter windows appeared only on early 1983.5 production. Glued-in side glass with metal trim means a 1984 to early-1985 build. Front-door vent windows ended in 1988. A 1984 fuel tank has a smaller sending-unit opening than 1985–90 tanks.

NOTES

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